男子家を出ずれば七人の敵あり、と言う。

殊に会社経営の傍ら、県議も務める身なればなおのこと。二足の草鞋を履きながら、おっとり刀で駆けつけるたび、都合十四の敵がいる。

It is said that when a man steps out of his house, he has *seven* enemies.

Particularly when not just managing an esteemed business, but also when working as a prefectural assembly member, this is all the more true. Wrangling with *two* positions, rushing out of my house with sword in hand each day, I have *fourteen* enemies in total.

無論、味方も数多くいるが、面従腹背の輩が面子をかける伏魔殿では、心安く接せられる関係は望めない。そも、社会に出てからこの方、利害や打算抜きに、真実真心をもって人と付き合ってきた覚えがない。それは肩書きの有無にかかわらず、いわゆる世間一般の大人であれば多くの者が感ずるところであろう。

それゆえ、男子家を出ずれば七人の敵あり、という言葉には常に実感が伴っている。

Of course, I do have many allies, but I can’t expect a close relationship amongst the pandemonium that is the workplace, where backstabbers lurk behind every corner. After all, ever since stepping foot into society, I can’t remember a single genuine interaction with anyone that didn’t involve cold calculation or pure self-interest. Regardless of job title, I’d wager that this is something that most adults have experienced at one point or another.

That’s why that saying, that when a man steps out of his house, he has seven enemies, resonates so profoundly with me.

しかし、その手のことを表立って口にするほどに愚かではない。昨今の風潮を鑑みれば、男子に限定すること自体が実に前時代的だと批判されることは想像に難くなく、また周囲の人々を敵と断ずるはレイシズムととらえられかねない。

何より、我が家においてそんなことを口走ってしまえば、あの空恐ろしいほどに整った美麗な顔立ちでもって、『あら、では家の中なら敵はいないのかしら』などと薄い微笑みを投げかけられてしまうに違いないのだ。

However, I’m not so foolish as to go around saying these things out loud. Bearing in mind where our societal norms are trending, it isn’t hard to imagine that the notion that this is something only men experience would be lambasted, or that assuming everyone around you as an enemy could be taken as some form of racism.

More than anything, if some of these grumblings were to inadvertently slip in my own household, there’s no question that I’d be met with something bone-chilling along the lines of, “Ah, then surely you don’t have any enemies in this household, do you?”, words mouthed by refined looks and beautiful faces as they let out an ever-so-slight smile.

その問いかけに否と即答できないのがなんとも歯がゆい。彼女たちを敵だと断ずるつもりはまったくないが、けれど、味方であるとも言い切れないのが悩ましいところだ。

妻と娘たちは常であれば聖人君子や良妻賢母と称賛されてしかるべきだ。しかし、時に邪知暴虐の王をはるかに凌ぐ悪鬼羅刹の顔を見せる。

That I can’t immediately deny that question is terribly vexing. I don’t intend to label the women around me as enemies, but that I can’t exactly say that they’re allies is troubling.

In a vacuum, my wife is amazing and a wise mother, and my daughters are complete saints. However, from time to time, they will show a side that goes far beyond your average clever tyrant and stoops further into the territory of soul-eating fiend.

だからまぁ、差し引きすれば、小悪魔という表現に落ち着くのだろう。

……いや、その程度の形容ではやや不十分かもしれない。小悪魔と呼ぶにはいささか存在のスケール感が大きすぎる。怖い時はとことん怖い。特に妻は本当に怖い。長女も最近とても怖い。次女はひそかに怖い。

That’s why, at the end of the day, it’s probably safe to call them my little devils.

No, leaving it at that might not do it enough justice. Calling them my little devils implies that they’re small. But when they’re scary, they’re seriously scary. My wife in particular is super scary. My oldest daughter has been awfully scary recently. My youngest daughter is stealthily scary.

しかし、怖いからこそ、可愛らしさを見せた時の破壊力が圧倒的だ。あさま山荘事件における鉄球のように理性の壁をたやすく打ち砕く。

敵味方に色分けできず、小悪魔と呼ぶには可愛すぎて怖すぎる彼女たち。

But it’s because they’re so scary, that when their sweetness does come out, it is an overwhelmingly destructive force. Like the wrecking ball used during the Asama-Sanso incident, it easily smashes through all walls of reason in one fell swoop.

These are the women of my household: who are too sweet and too scary to be called little devils, and who can’t be classified as friend or foe.

であるならば、彼女たちは女神と呼ぶのがふさわしかろう。

あまたある神話や英雄譚において、女神は必ずしも味方として語られているわけではない。恐怖や混沌の象徴として存在することもある。

Since they’re like that, maybe it’s fitting to call them goddesses.

The many legends and epics don’t necessarily portray their goddesses as if they were allies. They also existed as symbols of fear and chaos.

妻も娘たちも、数々の神話に謳われる女神さながらに、慈愛と恐怖、両極端な性質を併せ持ち、気まぐれに下々の心を奪っていく。凛とした容貌の美しさもさることながら、ふとした瞬間に覗かせる少女のような愛らしさもまた女神らしいと言えるだろう。

男子家を出ずれば七人の敵あり。

雪ノ下家に帰れば、三柱の女神あり。

それゆえ、私は家に帰ったとて、心落ち着くことなどない。今日もまた彼女たちの気まぐれに私は振り回されることになるのだろうから。

My wife and daughters alike, as if they were the ones having their praises sung in these legends, embodying both extremes of love and fear, steal the hearts of mortals on a whim. It’s one thing to be beautiful and dignified, but their flashes of cute girlishness is likely what sets them apart as goddesses.

When a man steps out of his house, he has seven enemies.

When a man steps into the Yukinoshita household, he has three goddesses.

So just like any other day, when I came home, I couldn’t relax. Because today, like always, my fate will likely be decided at the whim of these women.

× × ×

後部座席の車窓を流れる景色の中、月明かりに夜桜が舞い散っていた。

赤信号に引っかかり、運転手がゆっくりと自動車を止めると、街灯で照らされた桜の枝先にほんのわずか、柔らかな葉が覗き始めているのが見えた。

既に四月も半ばに差し掛かっている。事務所やオフィスに引きこもってばかりいたせいで、時の移ろいに気づかずにいた。

Amidst the rushing scenery in the backseat window, the cherry blossoms fluttered against the moonlight.

Stopped by the red light, the driver eased on the brakes, and on the end of the cherry blossom branches, illuminated by the streetlights, the blooming of those tender leaves came to light.

It’s already near halfway through April. Because I've been cooped up at work the entire time, I never noticed the season passing by.

新たな年度に切り替わる慌ただしさからも解放され、私自身、どこか心に余裕が生まれてきたらしい。自宅とオフィス、事務所、さらには出先とめまぐるしく動き回っていたがようやく一息つくことができた気がした。

ぼんやりと眺めていると、信号が変わったのか、車はまた静かに走り出す。緩やかな加速も穏やかなブレーキングもプロのそれだ。私も若かりし頃はそれなりに乗り回した口だが、やはり運転を生業にしている専門家には遠く及ばない。義父について仕事を始めたばかりの頃は他人の運転になかなか慣れなかったが、今ではなんの違和感もなくなっていた。

Released from the chaos of the new fiscal year, somewhere within me, within my spirit, came a wave of calm. Having been tossed to and from my house, my offices, and everywhere in between, now been released from those, I realized I could finally take a breath.

As I was idly looking out the window, maybe because the signal changed, who knows, the car once again quietly took off. The driver accelerates and brakes so gracefully like the professional he is. In my younger days I could drive around decently in my own right, but of course I wasn't close to being good enough to make it a trade. When I was just starting work and my father-in-law was showing me the ropes, it felt a bit odd being driven around, but there’s nothing uncomfortable about it now.

我が家の前に到着し、運転手が後部座席へ回ってドアを開けてくれるのも、日常的なことだと受け入れてしまっている。

ありがとう。お疲れ様。おやすみ。また明日。

さて、自分は今どんな言葉を言っただろうかと思うくらいに、まったくの無意識で別れの挨拶を口にして車を降りた。

We reached the front of our house. The driver came around to the back to open my door, which is something I’ve taken for granted as an everyday happening.

Thanks. Thank you. Have a good night. See you tomorrow.

To the point where I couldn't tell you what words I actually used, I said my goodbyes with no sense of conscience, and hopped out of the car.

運転手は無言のまま一礼し私を見送ってくれる。それに私は首肯にも似た目礼を返して、門をくぐった。

まったく慣れというのは怖いものだ。

運転手の存在も、やけに大きい邸宅も、県議や会社の仕事も、新しい苗字にも、最初は戸惑いばかりだった。

Without saying anything, the driver took a short bow and saw me off to the house. I gave him a sort of nod of approval, and slipped through the gate.

To be completely used to it all is a scary thing.

Having a driver, our gigantic mansion, my work in the prefecture and in the business, my new surname, at first it all felt like being lost at sea.

そもそもこうした暮らしに縁遠かったというのもある。もともと政治の道やあるいは会社経営を志していたわけではなく、たまたま妻の実家がそうした一族だったというだけなのだ。

今でこそ女性の政治家も増えてきているが、当時は男性の方が割合としては圧倒的に多く、私も婿入りしての後継を望まれた。

Living like this was always beyond my means. From the start, it wasn't as if I was aiming for government or administrative work, my wife's family just so happened to be this family in particular.

Though right now the number of female politicians is on the rise, at the time males had an overwhelming majority in government, and I was also expected to be adopted into this family and take the reins.

私自身は別段継ぐというほど御大層な実家があるわけでなし、それが結婚の条件と言われれば二つ返事で受けるだけのこと。

免許や銀行口座その他諸々の書類関係の書き換えには辟易したものの、それくらいしか面倒ごとはなく、私はいつしか雪ノ下家の人間になっていた。

I, myself, don't come from a family high-profile enough that I would particularly want to inherit it, so if me taking on those responsibilities of her family was a condition for marriage, I would have accepted it in no time anyway.

While getting my license, bank account and all that other logistical paperwork straightened out was tiresome, it wasn't exactly bothersome. And so just like that, I became a part of the Yukinoshita family.

新たな姓を名乗り、義父の職や地盤を継ぎ、二人の娘にも恵まれた。

遮二無二仕事に打ち込むうちに、議員センセイや社長といった肩書きにも慣れ、今ではこれが自分の日常なのだという自覚が生まれていた。

だが、夫、そして父親という立場には未だ慣れていない。

I took on a new surname, I took over the work for my father-in-law, and I was blessed with two daughters.

While I was completely absorbed in my work, getting used to my lofty titles like "Mister Congressman" and "President", only now has the realization set in that this is my everyday life.

However, what I am still not used to is my title as "Husband" or "Father".

結婚時から起算して二十年以上のキャリアがあるはずだが、それでも充分に役目を果たしていると、胸を張って言うには少々自信が足りていないのが実情だ。娘たちが思春期に差し掛かってからはなおさらである。

陽乃と雪乃。

二人の娘は妻に似て、賢く美しく成長したが、だからこそ父としては時に心配にもなる。才色兼備であるが故にいらぬやっかみを受けはしまいか、雪ノ下の家は重荷になりはしまいか、可愛すぎるあまり変な虫が近づきはしまいか……。

From the start of my marriage I've led a career of over twenty years. But in reality, I don't have the confidence to say that I've lived out my duties to the fullest, or that I can puff out my chest.

Haruno and Yukino.

My two daughters resemble my wife, growing up smart and beautiful, but that's exactly why I worry for them as a father from time to time. They're both blessed with such smarts and beauty that they might be the targets of unnecessary envy, they might be crushed under the burden that is the Yukinoshita family, they're so cute that they might attract some weirdos...

心配事の種は浜の真砂がごとく、尽きることはないのだが、さりとてあれこれ口を出すのも憚られ、また鬱陶しそうな目で見られると悲しくもあり、私は今一つ娘たちと踏み込んだ話をすることができずにいる。

だが、父親が頼りない分、母親が厳しくも優しく、深い愛情を注いで接してきてくれた。その厳しさたるや、娘たちよりもまず私に対して厳しいくらいである。どれくらい厳しいかと言えば、昨今の市況くらい厳しい。厳しすぎるのではないだろうか。

Like grains of sand on the beach, my seeds of worry are countless. But as countless as they are, I'm hesitant to express them. I get a bit sad when I'm met with irritation, and so as of now I've found myself unable to have a single deep conversation with my daughters.

However, where I lack in being a father, my wife makes up for in being strict but kind in connecting with our daughters by showering them in deep love. About her strictness: she's far more strict with me than our daughters. If I had to describe how strict she was, I'd say she's as strict as the stock market nowadays. Isn’t that a bit too strict?

雪ノ下家の家業を継いだ当初から、早々に楽隠居を決め込んだ義父よりも妻の方が私の仕事に手厳しい評価をしてきた。おかげで私はいっぱしの仕事ができるようになったが、その分だけ、家に帰るのが怖くもなったものだ。いや、今でも多少は怖いが。

私は玄関へと入る間際、なんなら仕事の時よりも緊張感を高めて、ドアを開ける。

More than my father-in-law, who was just getting ready to slip into a comfortable retirement, my wife has heavily scrutinized my work ever since I took on the business. Thanks to that I've been able to do my job pretty darn well, but by the same token, coming home became much scarier. Even now, it's still a bit scary.

As I came to the door, a wave of nervousness, more serious than ever occurs at work, rushed over me. I opened the door.

すると、扉の先、上がり框には既に妻が出迎えに立ってくれていた。

「おかえりなさい」

和装にしっかりと髪を結いあげた妻はたおやかな笑みとともに緩やかに一礼する。その柔和な微笑みは出会ったころと変わらず、いやあのころよりも美しい。

「ああ、ただいま」

Already standing by the front door, there to greet me, was my wife.

"Welcome home."

Dressed in a kimono, with her hair firmly tied up, my wife elegantly smiled as she took a graceful bow. That gentle smile

is just as beautiful as when I first met her -- no, it's even more beautiful now than then.

"Hey, I'm home."

コートと鞄を受け取ろうと手を差し出してくれる妻に、ありがとうと礼を言いつつもかすかに首を振ってそれを固辞する。そも私はごくごく一般的なサラリーマン家庭の出であるため、こうした仰々しい出迎えや大和撫子然とした所作に免疫がないのだ。それは二十年以上経った今でも変わらない。

しかし、こちらへ差し出された手が下ろされることはなく、妻は無言のままにっこりとした笑みを浮かべている。

As my wife's arm reached out to take my coat and briefcase, I gave my thanks as I lightly shook my head to decline. After all, for someone as average a salaryman as can be like me, to be welcomed in such an exaggerated, Yamato Nadeshiko-like manner, is something I'm not accustomed to. That hasn't changed over these twenty-plus years.

However, without pulling back her outreached arm, my wife kept her smile without a word.

私が差し出すまでそのままでいるぞと言わんばかりの強い意志に根負けし、抱えていたコートだけを渡すと、ようやく引き下がってくれた。

別に鞄を預けるのが嫌なわけではなく、その心遣いは常に嬉しく思っているが、新婚の頃からの習い性なのだから仕方がない。今でこそ、鞄に大した物は入っておらず、手ぶらで出かけることも多くなったが、若かりし頃は期待や責任や意気込みも相まって鞄はずっしりと重かったのだ。時を経るにつれ、様々なものを預けることができるようになったが、しかし、その分だけ余計な重荷は背負わせまいと思って、私は今も自分で鞄を持つことにしている。

Against her resolute will, as if she was saying "I'm not leaving until you give it up", I gave in and handed her only my coat, and she eventually let me go.

It's not as if I don't want her taking my briefcase. I'm always happy for her thoughtfulness. But because this is how we've done things since we were newlyweds, it just can't be helped. Particularly now, there's nothing important stuffed in there. There are a lot of times when I go out carrying nothing. When I was younger, my briefcase was heavy with expectations, responsibilities, and enthusiasm. With time, I've become able to entrust my wife with many different things. But only to a degree. So as not to cause any extra burden, I still make it a point to keep my own briefcase.

まぁ、つまるところ、荷物を受け取ろうとする妻も、自分で持とうとする私も、似た者同士の頑固者なのだろう。

そんなことを思いながら、玄関から続く長い廊下をしずしずと歩く妻を見て、私は知らず微苦笑をこぼしていた。すると、妻がちらとこちらを振り返る。

「今日は陽乃も帰ってきてますよ」

「そうか。珍しいな」

Well, in the end, my wife, who keeps trying to take my briefcase, and I, who tries to keep it, are both equally as stubborn as they come.

While thinking about all this, I saw my wife quietly walking down the hall from the front door, and I unknowingly let out a wry smile. Right then, my wife took a quick turn toward me.

"Haruno is also coming home today."

"That so. That's unusual."

ついこないだ一人暮らしをしていた次女が戻ってきたかと思ったら、それと入れ違いに長女が家を出ていたのだ。私も仕事で家を空けていることが多いので、家族が揃

うのは正月以来になる。久しぶりの団欒の予感に、私の歩く速度が上がると、それと対照的に妻の足取りはやや重くなった。

「そうでもないでしょう。あの子はちょくちょく帰ってきますから」

Right as my second daughter, who has been living on her own for some time, returned, my oldest daughter passed her by and left the house herself. Because I have work, the house is empty quite often, and this will be the first time since the year started that our whole family will be together. Thinking about us all being together and talking for the first time in forever, I started walking faster, but contrary to my own, my wife's footsteps became heavier.

"It shouldn't be anything unusual. That girl comes back plenty often."

妻は頭痛でも堪えるかのようにこめかみに細く長い指先をあてると、呆れとも疲れともつかないため息を吐く。

「家を出る気があるのだかないのだか……」

「……そういうところも珍しいな」

私が言うと、妻ははてと小首を傾げた。そんなあどけない仕草や表情は出会ったころから変わらない。

As if she was suppressing a headache, my wife pushed her dainty, long finger to her temple, and, out of exasperation or tiredness, who knows, she took a deep breath.

"I'm not sure whether or not she truly wants to leave..."

"That's also quite strange, isn't it."

I said that, and my wife quizzically tilted her head to the side. Those adorable little gestures and facial expressions haven't changed since I met her.

妻は陽乃に期待をかけている分、どうしても厳しく接することが多い。陽乃がそれを煩わしく思っている節はあるものの、彼女も長子としての責任感からか、甘んじて受け入れてくれていたようだった。

だが、妻の口ぶりから察するに、その関係性はいささか変わったらしい。

Seeing as how my wife puts expectations on Haruno, there will naturally be many instances where my wife treats her harshly. While Haruno might occasionally find it troublesome, whether it's because of the responsibility she senses that comes with being the oldest child, she seems to have taken it with a sort of resignation.

However, judging from my wife's words, their relationship seems to have changed, if only slightly.

これまでであれば、妻は陽乃が家を出ることに否定的であったろう。今はまだ我が家の所有するマンションでの一人暮らしだから認めているにすぎなかった。しかし、先の言はいずれ実家を出ることを容認しているようにも取れる。妻のそうした態度はやはり珍しい。

さては私の知らない間に、妻と陽乃の間で何かあったかな……。などと考えつつ、ネクタイを緩めていると、ちょうどリビングへと差し掛かった。

If it were like before, my wife likely would've been pretty adamant about Haruno not leaving. She's only okay with it because the condo she's living alone in is owned by us. What's interesting is that what my wife just said could be taken as an implication that she has acknowledged that Haruno could one day leave our house. Honestly, that attitude is certainly strange.

Or, maybe something took place between my wife and Haruno without me noticing... Thinking something along those lines, I tightened my necktie and approached the living room.

寝室へと向かう間際、ちらりとリビングの様子を覗くと、雪乃と陽乃は何を話すでもなく、ソファに座り、思い思いの時を過ごしているようだ。

陽乃はロックグラス片手にテレビを眺め、上機嫌にけらけら笑っている。対して、はす向かいに座る雪乃はティーカップを手に文庫本のページを手繰っていた。だが、時折、思い出したようにスマートフォンを手にすると、ふっと柔らかな笑みを浮かべ、いそいそと何やら打ち込み始める。

Right before I headed for the bedroom, I took a glance toward the living room. Not saying a word to one another, seemingly lost in their own worlds, were Yukino and Haruno sitting on the sofa.

Staring at the TV was Haruno, with a rock glass in hand, laughing heartily. Sitting at the exact opposite corner, with teacup in hand, turning the pages of her paperback, was Yukino. But occasionally, as if she had just remembered something, she took her smartphone, gave off a soft smile and started excitedly typing something into it.

これまた珍しいこともあるものだ。雪乃があんな表情を見せるのは『岩合光昭の世界ネコ歩き』を見ているときくらいだと思っていたのに。SNSで猫動画でも投稿されていたのだろうか。いや、それにしてはどこか照れくさそうに足をばたばたさせ、クッションに顔を埋めるのは不自然だ。そも、雪乃が家でスマートフォンを身近に置いていること自体が珍しい。加えて言えば、雪乃のそんな奇行めいた素振りを陽乃がからかうでもなく、さもありなんとばかりに見て見ぬふりをしているのも不自然極まりない。

考えれば考えるほどに、疑問が深まっていく。寝室がある二階へと向かう階段を一歩また一歩と登っていくうち、私の想像は徐々に形を成していき始めた。

そして、寝室にたどり着くと同時に、疑問の答えにもたどり着いてしまう。

……まさかとは思うが、と、私が話しかけようとした矢先、クローゼットにコートをかけていた妻の方が先に口を開いた。

Yet another unusual happening. I thought the only time Yukino would let herself be seen like that would be when looking at something like "Mitsuaki Iwago: Cats Walk the World". Are cat videos being posted on SNS now? No, that can’t be what she’s looking at. She wouldn't be so flustered, bouncing her legs, nor would she be burying her head in her pillow like she is. Really, that Yukino is in this house and has her phone anywhere within her general vicinity in itself is strange. Moreover, that Yukino is acting this peculiar and that Haruno isn't poking fun at her, but that Haruno is pretending not to see her and is essentially acting as if that's just how it is, is as strange as it gets.

考えれば考えるほどに、疑問が深まっていく。寝室がある二階へと向かう階段を一歩また一歩と登っていくうち、私の想像は徐々に形を成していき始めた。

そして、寝室にたどり着くと同時に、疑問の答えにもたどり着いてしまう。

……まさかとは思うが、と、私が話しかけようとした矢先、クローゼットにコートをかけていた妻の方が先に口を開いた。

The more I think about it, the more I believe something has to be afoot. With each step up the stairs, which lead to the bedroom on the second floor, my imagination steadily began to take on a tangible form.

Then, right as I reached the bedroom, the answer to my doubts finally materialized.

Right as I was about to say something along the lines of "This might sound crazy, but...", my wife, putting on a coat in the closet, spoke first.

「そういえば二人とも、あなたに話があるようだけれど……」

瞬間、嫌な予感がした。

今しがたの雪乃の素振りに加えて、わざわざ改まって話がある、とくれば、その内容は自然と限られてきてしまうのではないだろうか。

"By the way, it seems like the two of them have something to talk to you about, but..."
At that very moment, I began to expect the worst.
Taking into account Yukino’s demeanor, adding the fact that they need to go out of their way to talk about it, the topic as good as naturally narrows itself down.

「……着替えたらすぐに行くよ」

震えそうになる声音を無理くり押さえつけて、努めて平静を装う。だが、そんな小手先の猿芝居はお見通しだったのか、妻がくすっと笑った。

“I’ll be there right after I change.”
As my voice verged on trembling, and as I did everything in my power to stifle it, I worked to contain myself. Unfortunately, my wife saw right through my cheap acting job, and she let out a giggle.

「ええ。では、お茶の準備をしてますから」

妻が先に寝室を出るのを見送って、私はのろのろと着替えを始める。

着慣れているはずの背広がやけに重い気がしてならなかった。

“Mm. Alright, I’m going to prepare the tea.”
I watched my wife walk out the bedroom, and then I clumsily started changing.
I couldn’t shake the feeling that my suit, the suit which I am so accustomed to wearing, had become unbearably heavy.

ゆっくりたっぷり時間を使って部屋着に着替え終えると、私はこれまたゆっくりと一段一段確かめるようにして階段を下りた。

それだけの時間をかけなければ覚悟を決めることができそうにない。

Slowly and surely, I finished changing into more relaxing clothes, and once again, I slowly and deliberately took the stairs, descending step by step.

If I hadn’t taken that much time, I don’t think I could have possibly prepared myself for what was about to go down.

なんせ今まで娘たちに浮いた話などなかったのだ。無論、見目麗しく愛らしい性格をした子たちだから、異性から注目されることは多かっただろう。だが、聡明なあの子たちは自身の容姿について正しく理解し、うまくあしらってきたのだと思う。

Not even until now have I never talked to either of my daughters about their love lives. It goes without saying that my children, beautiful in looks and lovely in personality, have certainly caught the eyes of men many times over. I do think that my children, though, being as wise as they are, are self-aware about their appearances, and I think they’ve acted accordingly.

なにより、二人の幼馴染みには葉山さんのところの隼人君がいる。幼いころから老若男女問わず人気で、周囲の大人たちからの受けもよかった彼を間近に見ていれば、並みの男子では相手にならないはずだ。彼と比較される男子諸君が可哀想になってくる。

The thing is, both of them are childhood friends with the kid from the Hayama family, Hayato. When taking into account how popular he was among boys and girls of all ages alike ever since he was little, and seeing up close how he’s been able to interact with all the adults around him, it’s safe to say no other guy stands a chance when lined up against him. I pity any guy that has to be compared to him.

いや、待てよ？　話というのは隼人君とのことについてという可能性もある。

葉山さんとは先代の頃より家族ぐるみでのお付き合いが続いているし、私も妻も彼には好印象を抱いている。娘たちが誰それと付き合うということになれば、その最有力候補に名前が挙がるのが彼だ。父としては複雑な気分ではあるが、もし万が一仮に彼が娘と良い仲になるというならそれを歓迎しないこともなくはないかもしれないとまでは言えないこともない。ない。

Wait, hold on a sec? It's possible that this talk could be about Hayato.

Through Hayato’s father, we've been associated with the Hayama family since the generation before us, and so me and my wife have a very good impression of Hayato. If my daughters were to go out with anyone, the guy who comes to mind as the prime candidate is certainly him. It’s a mixed bag of emotions for me as a father, but if by some chance he were to get a bit friendly with one of my daughters, it’s not as if I wouldn’t not be pushed to say that I wouldn’t probably not welcome it. Not.

端的に言えば、その手の話をあまり聞きたくはないというのが正直なところだ。しかしながら、娘たちから話があると言われてしまえば、それを断るのも気が引ける。私は父親として未熟だという自覚があるからこそ、娘たちのお願い事は極力叶えてやりたいと思っているのだ。

だんだんと気分が沈んでいくと、私の足音もひそやかなものへと変わっていく。リビングのドアノブを捻るときでさえ、物音一つ立てることはない。

Frankly, I don’t really want to be hearing about all of that. However, if my daughters told me that they had something to talk about, I’d be hesitant to turn them down. Because I know full well my shortcomings as a father, I want to at least try and grant whatever my daughters might wish for, to the best of my ability.

As my mood sank further and further, the sounds of my footsteps became something faint. Not even when twisting the doorknob to the living room did I make a noise.

暗澹たる気分でリビングのドアを開けると、ふわりと紅茶の香りが漂ってきた。ハイティーと呼ぶにはいささか遅い時間だが、妻と娘たちは三人揃ってお茶を楽しんでいる。

「わたしたちとはご飯行ったんだし、そうなると次はやっぱりお父さんじゃない？」

「絶対嫌。……というか、向こうが絶対嫌がるわ」

In my somberness, I opened the door, and the smell of black tea wafted around me. It’s a bit late to call it high tea, but there were my wife and two daughters, all gathered, enjoying the tea.

"Since you've already gone out to dinner with us, shouldn't it be time to go out with Dad next time?"

“Definitely not. ...I mean, he’s the one who wouldn’t want to.”

革張りのソファに沈み込んでいる陽乃がお茶菓子をひょいと口に放り込みながら、なにやら気になることを言っていた。一方、話しかけられたと思しき雪乃はティーカップを指先でつまみ上げると、実に苦そうに紅茶を飲む。

「そういうものよ。お父さんだって、最初はすごく嫌がっていたもの。けれど、それをうまく誘導するのが……」

Sinking into the leather couch, and popping a teacake into her mouth, Haruno was having her share of rather interesting things to say. On the other side, appearing to be on the other end of the conversation, was Yukino, raising her teacup with her fingertips and drinking her tea as if it were rather bitter.

“That’s just the way it is. I mean, at the start, your Dad, being your Dad, was definitely not having it. But if we were to draw him out...”

言いかけた妻は、ドアの横で亡霊のようにぼーっと立ち尽くしている私を見つけると、言葉の続きを飲み込んで、空のティーカップに紅茶を注ぎ始めた。

その所作で気づいたのだろう、陽乃と雪乃も私の方へ振り返る。

「あ、おかえりー」

「おかえりなさい……」

My wife, still mid-sentence, looked over at me, standing faintly like a ghost next to the door. Stifling her next words, she began pouring tea into her empty cup.

Likely noticing their mother do so, Haruno and Yukino also turned my direction.

“Ah, you’re back--”

“Welcome home...”

陽乃は気安く、雪乃は気まずげに声をかけてくれる。久しぶりに家族が揃った姿に、私は知らず安堵にも似た吐息を漏らしていた。

「……ああ、ただいま」

妻が淹れてくれた紅茶を手に、私もソファに座る。長く使い込んだ革は、腰を下ろすと緩やかにたわみ、優しく包み込んでくれるようだった。あるいは、家族もそうしたものなのかもしれない。最初は硬く、強張っていても、長い時を経て、丁寧に手入れをしていくことで、やがてしっくりと馴染んでくる。ふふっ、夜毎ぴかぴかに磨いてきてよかった……。

Haruno doing so familiarly, and Yukino doing so uncomfortably, both greeted me. Coming home to see my family all gathered for the first time in forever, I subconsciously let out what felt like a breath of relief.

“Ah, yeah... I’m home.”

With the tea that my wife brewed in hand, I also sat on the sofa. The long worn down leather softly gave into my legs as I

sat into it, as if the leather was gently wrapping itself around them. Maybe this couch is exactly what a family is: though tough and stiff at the start, given enough time and care, it eventually softens up quite nicely. Heh, am I glad I polish it every night...

などと、ひとり悦に入っていると、お茶菓子をあむあむしていた陽乃が紅茶でそれを飲み込み、先の会話の続きを口にする。

「……まぁ、嫌がるのはわかるけど、あんま時間かけてもねぇ。もう既成事実作って追い込んじゃったほうが早くない？　どうせあの子、逃げらんないんだし」

As I was caught up in my own self-satisfaction, Haruno, munching on teacakes, and washing them down with a swig of tea, started talking once again from where the conversation left off.

"Well, I get that he might not like it, but we shouldn't linger on it. It's a done deal, so isn't it faster if we just make him go with it? I mean, that boy's not going anywhere."

出し抜けに言われた言葉に私の腰がずるりとソファから滑りそうになってしまった。ふふっ、どうやら夜毎ソファを磨きすぎてしまったかな……。ふふっ、もうつるっつるだよつるっつる。ふふっ、おかげで『あの子』や『既成事実』といった単語もうまいことつるっと聞き流すことができた。ふふっ、夜毎ぴかぴかに磨いてきてよかった……。

気を取り直して、よっこいせっと座りなおすと、それを見計らったように今度は妻が指を口元に当て、ふむと考えるような仕草を見せる。

Words so unexpected, my bottom almost slipped off the couch. Heh, it seems that I've polished the couch a bit too much every night... Heh, man is this thing slippery. Heh, thanks to that, even the words 'that boy' and 'done deal' can slip in one ear and out the other. Heh, am I glad I polish it every night...

With a grunt, I sat up straight and gathered myself. This time, as if she saw that coming, my wife put a finger to her lips as though she were considering something.

「既成事実の種類にもよるわね。もう少し見極めたほうがお互いのためでしょう。もっとちゃんと調べてから、ある程度将来性の担保をとってからでないと……」

「そんなこと言ってたら誰かに取られちゃうよ。ねぇ？」

"It also depends on what kind of deal. It's in the best interests of both of you to be a bit more certain. Only after you truly, thoroughly learn more about him, and make sure your future is secure can you then..."

"Keep saying that and he'll be snatched up by someone else. Right?"

陽乃が傍らへからかような笑みを向けると、雪乃はむっと唇を尖らせ、不満げな視線を返す。だが、それよりもなお鋭い眼光を見せたのは、妻だった。

「……その可能性は否定できないわね。特にあの子たちが厄介そうだわ」

「あー、あの二人ねー」

「そんなことない、と思うけれど……」

Haruno cast a mocking smile to the side, and Yukino pursed her lips into a pout, giving a sour look right back toward Haruno. But sharpest of the three, pointing with a keen gaze, was my wife.

"I can't really deny that possibility. Those two girls in particular seem troublesome..."

"Oh, right right right-- those two--"

"I don't really think it's like that..."

雪乃があうあうあわあわしながら、取り繕うように口を開く。しかし、雪乃自身、その言葉に確たる信念があったわけではないようで、うぐぅと考え込むように顔を伏せてしまった。

そんな雪乃を見て、妻も陽乃もふっと口元を綻ばせる。微笑ましいものを見た、と言わんばかりだ。

As if in an attempt to smooth over the conversation, Yukino began speaking in a frenzy. It didn’t seem as if she herself firmly believed in what she had just said, and she couldn’t help but lower her head, as if in deep consideration.

Seeing Yukino like that, my wife and Haruno each broke out into a smile. How amusing, said their faces.

私もまた同じように薄い微笑みを浮かべてはいたものの、内心穏やかではいられない。先ほどから会話の端々に不穏な気配を感じる。

紅茶をちびちび飲みながら、話が途切れた瞬間を見計らって私はおもむろに口を開いた。

「何の話をしているんだい？」

「し、知らない……」

While I had also let out a faint smile, I couldn’t stay calm on the inside. Having heard every turn of the conversation, I felt my creeping sense of dread.

While sipping my tea, monitoring for lulls in the conversation, I deliberately started talking.

“What exactly are you talking about?”

“Wh-- Who cares...”

雪乃がふいっと顔をそらす。おや、久しぶりに見た稚い反応だ。うちの娘はどちらも可愛いが、今日は輪をかけて可愛い。妻？　妻はいつも可愛い。

しかし、雪乃にそんな可愛らしい反応をされてしまったおかげで、私の嫌な予感は、ほとんど確信へと変わっていた。

ことここに至れば、私も覚悟を決めるほかない。

Yukino swiftly turned away. Ooh, been a long time since I’ve seen that kiddish a reaction. My daughters have always been cute, but they’ve certainly stepped it up a notch today. My wife? My wife is always cute, of course.

However, it’s exactly because Yukino reacted in such a cute manner, that my worst fears have essentially been confirmed.

I don’t have a choice. The only thing I can do is brace myself.

「……そういえば、何か話があると母さんから聞いたが」

父親の威厳を保ちながら、私はダンディにそう切り出し、ティーカップを静かに下ろした。一瞬の静寂がリビングに満ちる。

……はずだったのだが、不思議なことに私の手元ではカップとソーサーがかちゃかちゃ音を立てていた。

ああ、嫌だ……、聞きたくない……。

“Come to think of it, I heard from your mother that we had something to talk about...”

Asking nonchalantly, and giving off all the airs of a dignified father, I gently put down my teacup. A sudden silence filled the room.

...is what I expected, but for some odd reason the teacup and saucer in my hands were making a clattering noise.

God... I do not want to hear this...

私は雪乃の顔をまともに見ることができず、波立つ紅茶をじっと見つめていた。

すると、誰かが、んっと小さな咳払いをする。

ふと顔を上げると、そのことだけど……と、切り出したのは陽乃だった。

Unable to even look at Yukino straight in the eyes, I stared intently into my rippling tea.

Right then, someone cleared her throat.

I suddenly lifted my head up, but Haruno, starting with “about that...”, was the one who broke the silence.

「わたし、またしばらくこっち戻ってくるから」

あっけらかんとした様子で続ける陽乃に、私はつい破顔していた。

「なんだ、一人暮らしはもう飽きたか」

なーんだ、話があるのは陽乃のほうか。なーんだ、よかった、お父さん安心しちゃったよ。私の笑み含みの声音に、しかし、陽乃はうーんと考えるように小さくうなった。

"I'm coming back home for a bit again."
Seeing Haruno going on indifferently, I broke out into a broad smile.
"What, are you already tired of living alone?"
Well, well. Is this talk just about Haruno in the end? Well, well, I'll have you know that your Dad's pretty darn relieved. My smile snuck into my voice, but Haruno let out a murmur of contemplation.

「そういうんでもないんだけど、ちょっとやりたいことがあって」

ちらと妻に視線をやると、楚々とした仕草で紅茶のお代わりを淹れてくれていた。別段異論をはさまないところを見ると、陽乃がこちらへ戻ってくることに関しては妻も了解しているのだろう。

であれば、私がとやかく言うようなことでもない。むしろ、かつての陽乃が門限破りは当たり前、無断外泊上等と言わんばかりの生活を送っていたことを考えれば、実家へ戻ると言ってくれるのは歓迎すべきことだ。いや歓迎どころの騒ぎではない。熱烈歓迎中華飯店だ。

"Not really, there's just something I want to do."
I glanced over at my wife, who was brewing more tea in a graceful manner. Seeing that she wasn't going to object at all, she's probably known for some time that Haruno was going to come back home.
If that's the case, I can't exactly complain. The Haruno we've always known has blown over curfews as if they were nothing and stayed out overnight as if she were daring us to do something about it. Considering that, we should be welcoming her back home with open arms. Actually, that we should be 'welcoming' her back is an understatement. It should be one of those overdone fervent greetings you get at a Chinese restaurant.

「何をやりたいかは知らないが……まぁ、好きにしなさい」

「ん、そうする。留学の準備とかしたいし」

　ぶっと思わずお茶を吹きそうになってしまった。というか、普通に吹き出していた。

「りゅ、留学!?」

　吐血したように口元をたらりと紅茶が伝う。ローテーブルにはぽたぽたと水滴が落ちていた。雪乃が箱ティッシュを無言で差し出せば、陽乃が二、三枚引き抜いてさっとふき取る。それをくるくる丸めて屑籠へぽいと放ると、私に向き直り、小首を傾げた。

"No clue what you want to do... But do whatever you want."

"Mhm, I'll do that. I kind of want to start preparing for study abroad."

I almost spat out my tea. Nope, I actually did spit it out.

"St-- Study abroad!?"

Tea dripped from my lips as if I had just coughed up blood. Drops of tea had trickled onto the living room table. Right as Yukino grabbed a tissue box without a word, Haruno swiped a few tissues and quickly mopped up. Rolling them up and tossing them into the garbage basket, Haruno turned to me, her neck tilted to the side.

「言ってなかったっけ？」

「聞いてないなぁ……」

　私は首をひねりながら、そのついでに妻の方を見る。だが、妻は驚いた様子もなく、楚々とした様子でお茶を飲んでいた。

「私は、反対しましたよ」

こちらを見ることもなく、小声でしれっとそう言った。言外には判断を私に預けるというニュアンスが滲んでいる。

"Did I not mention it?"
"I certainly didn't hear it..."
While tilting my own neck in puzzlement, I looked over at my wife. But my wife, completely unfazed, in a graceful manner, took a sip of her tea.
"I was against it at first."
My wife spoke softly without so much as a glance my way. The implication that any judgment to be delivered was solely in my hands was apparent.

口ぶりから察するに、妻と陽乃の間では侃々諤々のやりとりがあった後なのだろう。そのうえで、最終的な裁可を私に任せると……。

ふむ……。これまでであれば、妻の意見は絶対であり、陽乃はそれに反発しながらも自分なりにうまく折り合いをつけて従うという形が多かった。だが、今は妻も陽乃の意見を尊重しているように見える。

From her wording, it seems that my wife and Haruno have already had their fill of heated debate with each other. And on top of that, it seems like they’ve left me with the final say...
Hmm. My wife's say has always been absolute. But there have been many instances in which Haruno, while rebelling, will be able to masterfully negotiate her way through all kinds of situations, while still obeying in the end. But right now, it seems that my wife really is regarding what Haruno has to say.

まぁ、陽乃ももう二十歳。そろそろ口やかましく言うだけでなく、一人の大人として扱い始めるべき頃合いだ。だからこそ妻も頭ごなしに反対するわけではなく、対話の場を設けたのだろう。

しかし、いくつになっても娘は娘。父は父。それが変わることはない。不変の真理なのだ。

Well, she's also already 20. Nagging her is one thing, but it's about time we started treating her like a proper adult. I would think that's exactly why my wife has given Haruno space for dialogue rather than viciously antagonizing her.

But in the end, no matter how old you are, a daughter is a daughter. A father is a father. That will never change. It's an unwavering truth.

よーし、パパ、ちょっと粘っちゃうぞー。なぜなら、私は娘には家にいてほしいタイプの父親だからだ。

私はわずかばかりの抵抗を試みる。

「語学留学なら昔行ってるじゃないか。別に今更行かなくても……」

Okay pops, you got this, just a little bit more -- because I'm the type of Dad who wants his daughter in the house.

First, let’s try putting up a bit of a fight.

"If you're talking about a language study abroad, haven't you gone before? It’s not as if you have to go now..."

娘たちは一時期、海外へ留学している。帰国子女ということもあって、国際教養科なる課程がある高校を選んだのだ。語学目的であればこれ以上は必要なかろう、おうちにいようよ……と、続けようとすると、陽乃はにっこり笑って、その先を打ち切った。

「そうなんだけど、今度は長期で行きたいなーって。もっと専門的なこと勉強したいし、できれば一年くらいは行くつもり」

My daughters have studied overseas before. They've been through the whole experience of coming back home after being

abroad for a while, and so they both chose a high school which offered a program in international studies. If you wanted to study languages, then that should've been enough already, just stay at home man... Before I could get that out, Haruno cracked a broad smile and continued talking herself.

"Sure, but this time I thought it'd be nice if I could do it long term or something... I want to study something more applicable professionally, and if I could it'd be for a year."

陽乃はさらりと、まるで決定事項のように言ってのけた。こういう言いざまは本当に妻によく似ている。こうなると、私が反駁することなど叶うはずもなく、苦い顔で頷くほかない。

「……そ、そうか。うん……。いや、ただ、お金がな……」

Smoothly and without hesitation, Haruno declared so as if it had already been decided. She sounded almost exactly like my wife. I didn't even have as much of a prayer of a rebuttal, having no choice but to bitterly nod in resignation.

"...I-- I see. Right... Well, hold on... about the money..."

学業に専念できるだけのしっかりした環境を揃えようと思えば、数百万かかることになる。その額はさすがにぽんと出せるものではない。

いや、娘のためならば工面できないこともないが、金銭的と言うよりは心情的には出しづらい。だって一年だよ？　それも海外だよ？　心配にもなるよ。それも陽乃だし。絶対トラブル起こすよ。

Right when you've thought you'll try and send your kid to a proper school that allows them to devote themselves entirely to their studies, it turns out it'll actually set you back tens of thousands of dollars. Not exactly an amount of money you can just throw around.

Well, if it's for my daughters it's not like I can't find a way, but it's harder to pay up on an emotional level than it is on a financial level. I mean, it's a whole year, right? And it's overseas, you know? I get worried. Also, this is Haruno we're talking about here. She's definitely starting trouble.

陽乃は派手にわかりやすく揉め事を起こすタイプなのだ。対して雪乃は地味に気付かないうちにのっぴきならない状態になっていることが多い。つまり、二人ともトラブルを起こしがちなのだ。妻？　妻はもうトラブルどころかトラウマを引き起こしがち。

私が言葉を濁して渋っていると、それにしびれを切らしたのか、陽乃があっけらかんと言い放った。

「マンション売ればなんとかなるんじゃない？」

「あれはお父さんの持ち物なんだが……」

「名義は私ですけどね」

Haruno is the type to start very straightforward yet exuberant fights. As for Yukino, being as reserved as she is, she inevitably gets into something before one notices anything amiss. Basically, there's almost always something going on with each of them. My wife? My wife doesn't start trouble. She starts trauma.

Haruno, perhaps tired of me vaguely stumbling over my own words, nonchalantly asserted herself.

"Can't you make something happen if you just sold my condo?

"You know, that’s my condo..."

"It's under my name, you know."

妻が『忘れてないですよね？』と言わんばかりにちくりと素早く刺してくる。そうでしたね、購入するときに二人で話し合ってそう決めましたね。わかってますよ、もちろん覚えてますよと私が妻に笑顔で振りうん向くと、その隙に陽乃がしれっと何か言い足していた。

「でも、そのうちわたしのものになるじゃない」

「う、うん、まぁ、そうかもしれないが……」

As if to say "You haven't forgotten, have you?", my wife swiftly cut in. Right, when we bought it, we decided on that, didn't we. So, as if to say "I got it, of course I remember", I myself turned to my wife with a smile, but right then Haruno nonchalantly chimed in again.

"But one of these days it'll become mine."

"A- Ahh, well, that might be true, but..."

さも当然といった様子で、あまりにも堂々と言うものだから私もうまく否定できない。確かに相続する可能性は充分にあるが、うちの娘は君一人じゃないんだが……。

と、苦々しく思っていると、もう一人の相続者が控えめに手を挙げた。

I couldn't fight back against Haruno, who had so brazenly spelled it out as if it were truly the most natural thing in the world. It's completely possible that you'll inherit it, but you're not exactly my only daughter...

As I was bitterly mulling that over, the other successor in question reservedly raised her hand.

「姉さんが戻るなら、私が住むつもりでいるのだけれど……」

空気を窺うようにおずおずと口を開いた雪乃に、陽乃が意外そうな顔をする。

「え、そうなの？」

私もまた、陽乃とまったく同じ顔をしていたことだろう。え、そうなの？　なんで？　おうちいなよ。いてほしい。せっかく帰ってきたんだし……。

ぶつくさ言いそうになるのを私はぐっと飲み込んで、父の威厳を込めてこふっと咳払いする。

"If Haruno's coming back, then I was planning on living there..."

As if she was trying to read the room, Yukino sheepishly began talking, and Haruno gave off a look of surprise.

"Wait, really?"

I probably made the exact same face Haruno did. Wait, really? Why? Just stay here... Come on, stay. You just got here...

Swallowing my grumblings, I cleared my throat with all the airs of a dignified father.

「雪乃が私にしたかった話というのはそのことかい？」

妻は『二人とも話がある』と言っていた。であれば、雪乃もまた私に何か相談事を抱えているはずだ。

「え、ええ……、まぁ、それもある、というか……、それだけではないけれど……」

だが、雪乃から帰ってきた言葉はやや歯切れが悪い。

"Was this what Yukino wanted to talk to me about?"

My wife had said "both of them have something to talk about". Logically, Yukino should still have something to talk to me about.

"R- Right... Well, there's that, but that's not exactly everything..."

The thing is, Yukino had never expressly said out loud that she was coming home.

普段ならすぱっと言い切る子なだけに、その反応をやや訝しんでじっと視線を向けていると、雪乃は言いづらそうに俯いてしまった。

雪乃は何か言いたげに口元をもにょらせていたが、しかし、それがまともな言葉になることはない。彼女の中で考えがまとまるまで待っていると、やがて雪乃はゆっくりと、視線だけを上にあげ、ぽしょりと呟くように言った。

「……だめ？」

She's normally the type to speak clearly without hesitation. I cast a dubious look toward her, and there she was, staring at the floor as if there was something she couldn't get out.

Still wanting to speak, she bit her lip, but no proper words were coming out of her mouth. I waited until she had gathered her thoughts, and at last, she slowly lifted her gaze upward, faintly mumbling.

"...Is that okay?"

いいに決まってる！　いいに決まってるじゃないか！　雪乃のお願いなら何でも叶えちゃうぞ！　と、声高に叫びそうになった言葉を、何食わぬ顔でごくりと飲み込む。

「まぁ、今のところは使う予定もないが……」

言いながら、ちらと横目で妻の様子を窺うと、妻も異論を挟む素振りはない。ということは、これも私が判断すべきことなのだろう。

Of course it's fine! Of course it's totally fine! I'd make anything happen for Yukino! -- On the brink of shouting those out, I contained myself, reassuming my airs, and swallowed my words.

"Well, we don't really plan on using it as of now..."

While talking, I threw a quick glance at my wife, but she didn't seem as if she was going to step in. Which essentially means, this much is up to me.

「……好きにしなさい」

なんとかぎりぎりのところで、父親の威厳を発動させ、私は鷹揚に頷いて見せる。すると、雪乃はぱぁっと顔を輝かせた。

「ありがとう」

その微笑みが見られるなら、マンションの一つくらいどうということもない。人に貸せばそこそこ良い値がとれる物件だが、そんなものより雪乃の笑顔のほうが価値がある。娘の笑顔、プライスレス。

"...Go for it."
Running on fumes at this point, I again mustered up my dignity, and nodded to look as collected as I could be. Right then, Yukino's face lit up.
"Thank you."
If I can see that smile on her face, one condo is nothing. I could rent it out at a good price, but Yukino's smile is far more valuable. The smile of my girl, priceless.

実際、雪乃がおねだりしてくることは非常にまれなことなのだ。私や妻に要求がある時は、筋道立てて理路整然とプレゼンをしてくる。だから、今のように理屈も何もなしにねだられてしまうと、私は激弱なのだ。

雪乃も陽乃も、方法論こそ違えど、私へのお願いごとが上手だ。可愛い娘のためならばと、こっちは思ってしまうのだ。妻？　妻ももちろん可愛いの妻のためならばと思わされてしまう。いつも事後報告で『マンション、買いましたので』『名義、変更しましたから』『定期に入れてても仕方ないので米国債に変えましたよ』と、すべてが終わった後にわざわざ教えてくれるあたりに可愛げがあるので、非常に可愛いといえよう。可愛さ余って怖さ百倍だ。

It’s incredibly rare for Yukino to plead for anything. Whenever she does have something to ask for, she usually gives a logically sound, well thought out presentation to me and my wife. That’s why at times like now, being pleaded to by Yukino without any logical backing whatsoever, I am at my absolute weakest.

While their methods are completely different, Yukino and Haruno are both very good at asking me for things. I slip and think, ‘Well, if it’s for my sweethearts...’. As for my wife? Of course. I’m forced to think, ‘Well, if it’s for my darling wife...’. She always tells me “I bought a condo”, “I changed the surname on it to mine”, “It’s pointless to pay a fixed deposit, so I used US bonds”. That I have no say in any of this, and that I’m only in the know after the fact, is why her cuteness truly abounds. This makes her all the more cute. So cute that it’s horrifying.

しかし、せっかく実家に戻ってきてくれたのに、またすぐさま出ていかれてしまうのか。寂しいなぁ……と、私が肩を落とすと、それとほとんど同時に陽乃がはてと首をひねった。

「雪乃ちゃん、あっちに戻る必要なくない？」

陽乃の言葉に私も賛意を示して頷く。戻る必要なくない？　ないよね？　うちにいればよくない？　うちにいなよ。いてほしいなぁ……。

But is she seriously going to leave right after just getting back home? How lonely it is... Right as I lowered my shoulders in dejection, Haruno tilted her head in puzzlement.

“Yukino, it’s not like you need to go back, right?”

Hearing Haruno, I nodded in agreement. It’s not like you need to go back, right? Right? Isn’t being here nice? Just stay here. It’d be nice if you stayed...

「あっちのほうが通学に便利なの。もともとそういう理由で住んでたわけだし……」

雪乃はため息交じりにそう言うが、実情はやや違う。

そも、あのマンションに雪乃を住まわせることに決めたのは彼女が入学して以降のことだ。最初から利便性を求めて、一人暮らしをしていたわけではない。

結果的に、通学に便利になったのであり、因果が逆だ。**

“It’s easier to get to school from there. That’s why I started living there in the first place..."

Yukino said this, mixing in a sigh. But that was a bit off from the truth.

It was only after Yukino started going to school that it had been decided that she would live in the condo. She wasn’t living alone for an easier commute ‘in the first place’.

An easier commute was the result. Not the reason.

雪乃が一人暮らしをするに至ったもっとも大きな原因は、入学間際の交通事故だ。幸い、雪乃に怪我はなかったが、それでも少なからず精神的な衝撃はあっただろう。私も妻も被害者の方へのお詫びや後処理などで多少バタバタしていたこともあり、それらから遠ざける意味もあって、彼女に一人暮らしを勧めた。

あの頃の雪乃はややナーバスになっていたし、あまり折り合いの良くなかった陽乃と距離を置かせようと思ったのも理由の一つだ。

私の中で、雪乃は繊細な子という印象が強い。

The biggest reason Yukino started living alone was the car accident that happened right after school had started back up. Yukino came out physically unscathed, thankfully, but she probably endured a good deal of trauma. Between apologizing and seeing to the person hit by the car, there was quite a bit of

commotion at the time. So we suggested to Yukino that she live alone to get away from it all.

Being as shaken up as she was, and not having the best relationship with Haruno to begin with, another reason Yukino started living alone was to put some distance between the two.

In my mind, Yukino gives off a strong impression of being delicate.

無論、陽乃が繊細でないという意味ではない。陽乃も充分に繊細だが、その性質や方向性が異なるのだ。陽乃は硝子細工のような繊細さで、砕ければその破片が触れたものを傷つける。対して雪乃は触れればそのまま消え行ってしまいそうな儚さを伴っている。

妻？　妻ももちろん繊細だ。その性質や方向性は例えるなら触れた者が死ぬタイプの危険物。よって、その取り扱いにはかなりの繊細さが(できれば危険物取り扱いの資格も)求められるので、やはり非常に繊細な女性だと言わざるを得ない。

問題はその繊細な彼女たちが、結構気軽にお互いを傷つけあう節がある点である。

今も陽乃は雪乃にしなだれかかり、チェシャ猫めいた笑みを浮かべて、しきりに絡んでいた。

This isn't to say that Haruno isn't delicate either. She's plenty delicate herself, but the two are delicate in their own ways. Haruno's version of delicate is like glasswork: when shattered, she cuts anyone who touches her. On the other hand, Yukino is delicate in a fleeting sense: when touched, she simply fades away.

As for my wife? Of course she's delicate. As an example, she's delicate in the same sense that hazardous goods are: anyone who touches her dies. Because handling her requires a large degree of delicateness in and of itself (and, if possible, the ability to handle said hazardous goods), I don't have a choice but to call her an extremely delicate woman.

The issue is that these delicate women have a tendency to cut each other up without much reservation. Like now. Haruno

slithered up to Yukino, smiling ear to ear like the Cheshire Cat, and again began incessantly pestering her.

「別にうちからでもたいした距離じゃないでしょ～。ほんとにそれだけが理由かなぁ？」

「他にないでしょう。もっとも家から近いのに、ろくろく授業に出てない人にはわからないでしょうけれど」

雪乃はもたれかかってきた陽乃を押し返すと、そのついでにチクリとやり返す。

すると、それまで我関せずを貫いて優雅に紅茶を飲んでいた妻の動きがぴたりと止まった。

"It’s not like it’s that far from here. You sure that’s the only reason?”

“Of course that’s the only reason. I can see how someone who doesn’t go to class, despite how close it is, wouldn’t understand though.”

Yukino pushed back against Haruno, who was leaning on her, and bitingly retorted.

Right then, my wife, who had until now been gracefully drinking tea as if to say “not my problem”, suddenly froze.

「陽乃……。講義、受けていないの？」

ゆっくりとカップを下ろすと、底冷えのするような声音で呟く。表情は相変わらず柔和な笑みのままであるだけに、なお一層怖い。これにはさしもの陽乃もまずいと思ったのか、誤魔化すように紅茶を呷ると口早にまくしたてた。

「単位は落としてないんだからいいでしょ別に」

ここが好機と見たか、雪乃もにっこり笑って畳みかける。

“Haruno... Are you skipping lecture?”

Slowly lowering her cup, my wife spoke softly in a bone-chilling tone. Because her expression maintained her gentle smile, it was all the more scary. This was enough to faze even

Haruno, who tried to smooth over the conversation by downing her tea and talking frantically.

“I’m not losing any credit, so it should be fine.”

Sensing an opportunity, Yukino cracked a grin and asked a question of her own.

「あら？　あれだけ私たちにちょっかいをかけてきたのに、フル単だなんて、……さすがですお姉さま」

「し、進級するのには問題ないから！」

陽乃が私と妻に向かって、慌てて言い訳をする。進級には問題なし、ということは、裏を返せば最低限の単位しか取得していないということか……。

まぁ、陽乃は要領のいい子だから、学業に関してはさして心配はしていない。しかし、それはあくまで私の意見にすぎないようで、妻はまた違う意見らしかった。「陽乃……」と、優しくその名を呼んだ。

“Oh? Even after nagging all of us this much you’re still getting all your credits? Aren’t you special.”

“I— I’m still moving up a grade, so who cares!”

Haruno turned to me and my wife, frantically rattling off excuses. “Moving up a grade” is just another way of saying she’s doing the bare minimum, isn’t it...

Well, Haruno’s a capable enough kid, so I’m not too worried about her and her studies. But in the end, that’s just my opinion, and my wife seems to have a different one. “Haruno...", she said, calling her name in a voice as sweet as can be.

「あなたね、大学の授業が一コマいくらか一度計算してみなさい」

妻は頭痛をこらえでもするように、こめかみに指をあてると、深いため息を吐いた。そして、じとっと温度の低い眼差しを投げかける。

陽乃がうぐっと言葉を詰まらせる。その隣では雪乃がふふんと愉快そうに胸を反らしていた。

二対一と不利な情勢に追い込まれると、陽乃が助け舟を求めるようにむーっと唇を尖らせ私を見る。

“Go calculate how much one university credit hour costs.”

As if to suppress a headache, my wife put a finger to her temple, and sighed deeply. Then, calmly, she threw a chilling gaze her way.

Haruno’s words left her. Next to her was Yukino, triumphantly puffing her chest.

Two on one, driven into a corner, Haruno pouted toward me for help.

しかし、申し訳ないことに私にも覚えがあることなので何も言えない。

ずいぶんと昔にまったく同じことを言われたことがある。

昼日中から煙草の煙が充満した雀荘にこもりきりだった私に、彼女は今と同じく、辛辣な口ぶりと冷ややかな眼差しでもって、ちくちく言い募ってきたものだ。

あの時の光景を思い出すと、不意に、二十年前にやめた煙草の匂いを思い出す。当時は今の半額ほどの値段だったこともあり、一日にひと箱あけていたものだが、それも陽乃が生まれるときにやめてしまった。

Unfortunately for Haruno, I was in no position to say anything.

A long while ago, I was told to do the exact same thing.

That day, at the cigarette smoke filled Mahjong parlor, where I had been cooped up since noon, my wife gave me that same chilling gaze, complete with the same scathing tone as her words cut deeper and deeper.

My memory of that day is so vivid that when I do recall it, I suddenly also remember the smell of the smoke from the cigarettes I quit twenty years ago. At the time they were only half as expensive, and I smoked a pack a day, but when Haruno was born I quit entirely.

「……まぁ、サボりはほどほどにな」

苦笑交じりに言うと、妻からちろりと温度の低い視線を投げられた。それでも、学生時代に向けられていた凍てつく眼差しよりはまだいくらか温かくなっているのだから、伊達に二十年以上連れ添っていない。

私なりに中庸をとった発言のつもりだったが、陽乃は不満げに唇を尖らせ、ぶんむくれてそっぽをむいている。一方で隣に座る雪乃は得意げにさらりと髪を払い、勝ち誇っていた。

“Well, skip class in moderation.”

I said this with a wry smile, and my wife threw her chilling gaze toward me. But even then, her gaze was a bit warmer than it was in our own days at university. We haven’t been married for over twenty years for nothing.

I had only meant to take a word or two from Confucius, but Haruno’s face twisted further as she turned away in a huff. On the other side, sitting next to Haruno, Yukino triumphantly flipped her hair to the side, elated.

雪乃が陽乃をやりこめる様をずいぶん久しぶりに見た気がする。

だが、敵もさるものひっかくもの。

陽乃は何か思いついたらしく、閉ざしていた口元をほころばせると、そのまま口角を上げる。ふっくらとした唇がにまぁっと弧を描いた。

母譲りの嗜虐的な微笑みは親のひいき目なしにも美しいものだと思う。もっともその母は長じるにつれ、努めてポーカーフェースであろうと広げた扇子で隠すようになったが、陽乃は未だにあえて見せつけることで威圧に使おうとしている節がある。

I have a feeling this is the first time in a long time that I’ve seen Yukino shut down Haruno like that.

But you still can’t let your guard down against Haruno.

As if she’d just gotten an idea, Haruno, who’s mouth had been tightly shut until now, broke into a wide smile. Her soft lips drew an arc.

Even if I can't appreciate it as a parent, I think that those sadistic smiles, inherited from their mother, are a beautiful thing. Although said mother, as she raised her children, went on to hide that smile with her poker face or her hand fan or what have you, there's a good chance that Haruno is still showing off that smile to put on some intimidating airs of her own.

自然、その威圧的な微笑を見た雪乃も身構えた。あるいは、身構えるだけの猶予を与えた陽乃なりの優しさなのかもしれない。

根は優しい娘たちなのである。妻？　妻ももちろん優しい。特に理由はないし、これといった具体例は全く示せないが、優しいと言わざるを得ない。いや、優しいよ？

ほんとほんと。

「あ、そっかぁー……」

Naturally, having seen Haruno’s menacing smile, Yukino braced herself. Or maybe allowing Yukino just enough time to brace herself was Haruno’s own brand of kindness.

My daughters are definitely kind at heart. My wife? Of course she’s kind. I can’t bring up any concrete examples at all, nor do I have any rationale, but I don’t have a choice but to call her kind. She’s actually nice, though? For sure for sure.

“Ah, I see...”

陽乃はにやぁっと笑いながら呟くと、またぞろ隣にしなだれかかり、雪乃の長い黒髪を一房くるりと指で巻く。そして、その指先でもって雪乃の頬をつついた。

「実家だと、あの子を気軽に呼べないもんね。お泊まりだって難しくなるし。だからまた一人暮らししたいんだ」

「なっ」

Haruno mumbled with a gleeful smile. Slithering up to Yukino once more, Haruno twirled a tuft of Yukino’s long, dark hair around her finger. Then, with that same finger, she poked Yukino’s cheek.

“When we’re home, you can’t call that kid over that easily. Having them stay the night in particular is harder. That’s why you want to live alone again.”

“Hey...!”

瞬間、雪乃の背が跳ね、そのまま固まった。なんなら、私も完全に固まっていた。

え、待って。待って待って無理しんどい待って。

だめだぞ、いかん、そんなのお父さん許しませんよ。そいつの名前と住所とマイナンバーを教えなさい。ついでに、藁人形と五寸釘も用意してくれ。そしたら、金槌でダイレクトアタックしてくるから。

と、厳しく言いたかったのだが、あまりの衝撃に私は金魚のように口をパクパクさせることしかできない。

In an instant, Yukino’s spine straightened, then stiffened. Oh, one for me as well. My spine also completely stiffened. Wait, hold on. Hold on a second, good God, give me a second.

Nope, you can’t do that. Your Dad can’t let you, you know. Give me his name, address, and phone number. Also, get me a voodoo doll and a spike. I’m going to hammer it in and curse him proper!

...is what I wanted to say, sternly, but in my shock, all I could do was open and close my mouth aimlessly, like a goldfish.

落ち着け、落ち着くんだ。まずは紅茶を飲もう。それから金槌を探そう。

私が紅茶を飲むのと、雪乃がカップを呷るのとがほぼ同時だった。そして、雪乃は大きく息を吐くと、一気にまくしたてる。

Calm down. Just calm down. Let’s drink some tea. Afterwards, let’s go find a hammer.

At roughly the same time I drank my tea, Yukino downed the rest of hers. Then, after a deep breath, she began her frantic rambling.

「え、ええ、そうね。由比ヶ浜さんが気軽に泊まりに来ることは確かに難しくなったわね。けれど、それが理由なわけじゃないわ。現に私があちらにお邪魔することだってあるわけだし、私はただ純粋に通学に便利だからあのマンションに住むと言っているのだけれど」

言い終えると、雪乃は肩で息をしながら、空になったカップをゆっくりとソーサーへ置く。そこへ妻がすかさずお代わりを注いでいた。

雪乃はまっすぐすぎて、誤魔化すのが下手すぎる……。

しかし、知らない振りをしてやるのも親の務めというもの。

“Tha-- That’s true. It would certainly be much harder for Yuigahama to stay the night. However, that’s not the reason. In reality, I stay over at her place quite often. Genuinely, all I’m saying is that I just want to stay at the apartment because the commute is easier.”

Having finished speaking, her shoulders rising and falling from breathing, Yukino slowly placed her empty cup on her saucer. Without delay, my wife began pouring her another cup.

Yukino is far too honest, and she’s pretty terrible at hiding things...

However, it’s also the duty of a parent to turn a blind eye.

だいたい、娘の交友関係を逐一確認するのも過干渉というものだ。雪乃の口ぶりから察するに、どうやら由比ヶ浜さんと言うのは女の子のお友達のようだし、お互い家に行くような仲で常日頃から親しくしているように見受けられる。むしろ、あまり交

友関係の広くなかった雪乃が、それだけ心許せる友を得たというのなら、喜ぶべきことだ。

などと、どうにか自分をなだめすかしていたのだが、向かいに座っている陽乃はくつくつ楽しげに笑っている。ふいっと雪乃を抱き寄せて、耳元に顔を寄せたかと思うと、わざとらしくこちらに聞こえるように囁いた。

「いやいや、ガハマちゃんじゃなくて」

「姉さん黙って。黙りなさい」

In general, prying into my daughters' relationships, one by one, is a big overstep. Judging from Yukino's speech, it seems that this girl named Yuigahama is a friend of hers, and it seems that they're also close enough that they go over to each other's houses on a daily basis. For someone whose circle is as small as Yukino's, making a friend that close is really something to celebrate.

I tried to soothe myself, but sitting across from me was Haruno, who was snickering amusedly. She hugged Yukino close to her, putting her face to Yukino's ear, then, as if on purpose, whispering in a voice that I could hear.

"Nope! We're not talking about Gahama."

"Haruno, shut up. Just shut up."

雪乃は顔を背けると、両手で陽乃の口元をぐいぐい押して押さえにかかる。陽乃は頬をぐにぐに摑まれて、さながらオイタをしたときの犬みたいになっている。

姉妹のじゃれあいも随分と久しぶりに見た。

私が感慨に浸っていると、それまで呆れた様子で見ていた妻がおもむろに口を開いた。

「二人ともやめなさい」

Yukino turned her face away, and she forcefully squished Haruno's mouth with both hands. Her cheeks being grabbed as if they were dough, Haruno began to look like a mischievous dog.

It’s been quite a long time since I’ve seen those two play rough like that.
As I was basking in nostalgia, my wife, who to this point had been watching in exasperation, calmly opened her mouth to speak.
“Both of you. Stop it.”

妻が静かな声音で言うと、雪乃はしぶしぶ両手を下ろし、陽乃も肩に回していた腕を離す。

ようやく聞く態勢が整うと、妻はじっと雪乃を見つめた。

「そういったことも全部含めて、ちゃんとしたほうがいいでしょう。けじめはつけるべきだわ」

妻の声音はかつての、優しく甘やかすような、諭すような響きではなく、説き伏せるそれに変わっていた。

「……そんなの、絶対嫌がられる」

My wife said this in a quiet voice. Yukino reluctantly lowered her hands, and Haruno let go of Yukino’s shoulder.
Having restored order at last, my wife stared intently at Yukino.
“You should have said all of that at the start. Lines are meant to be drawn.”
My wife’s voice, once kind and lenient if not lightly scolding, changed to a more persuasive voice.
“He’d absolutely hate that.”

雪乃は浅く唇を噛むと、常よりもいくらか砕けた口調で続けた。その稚い喋り方が雪乃の小さいころを思い出させる。

「それに、面倒だって思われたり、重いって思われたら、……困る」

言って、しゅんと項垂れる雪乃の瞳には戸惑いや恐れ、あるいは思慕の念が溢れ、今にもこぼれそうだった。

Yukino lightly bit her lip, and continued in a manner less formal than usual. That innocent of a tone brought back memories of a much younger Yukino.

“And he’ll think it’s annoying. Also if he thinks it’s pushy, ...it’s tough.”

Saying this, Yukino’s eyes overflowed with confusion and fear and even affection, seeming as if they were about to spill over at any minute.

俺の娘にこんな顔させやがって……。どこの誰だか知らねぇけどぶち殺すぞこの野郎……。

膝の上で固く握り拳を作っていると、その手をぺしっと扇子で叩かれた。反射的に隣を見やると、妻が小さく首を振っている。

いかんいかん、危うく地が出そうになっていた。私は過去を反省した結果、寡黙ながらも良き父、良き夫であろうと誓ったのだ。

I don’t know who the hell made my daughter look like this, but I’m going to kill that bastard...

Hardening her fist on top of her knee, my wife slapped it with her fan. I looked over instinctively, and my wife gave a small shake of her head.

That was close. That could have been really bad. In silence, I reflected deeply on my past, and in the end, I vowed to be a good father and a good husband.

父として、悲しげに顔を伏せている娘になんと声をかけようか。考えていると、私が何か言うより先に、陽乃が動いていた。

陽乃は、からかってごめんね、とあやすように、雪乃の頭をぽんぽん軽く叩いた。

「大丈夫でしょ。それくらいあっちだってわかってるって。ていうか、雪乃ちゃんそもそも激重だよめちゃくちゃめんどくさいよ」

ぐしぐし撫でられると、雪乃はふいっと顔を逸らす。そして、照れくさそうにぽしょぽしょ文句を言った。

As a father, maybe I should say something to my daughter, who is currently hunched over gloomily. I thought about this, but before I could say anything, Haruno moved quicker.

As if to say, teasingly, that she was sorry, Haruno lightly knocked on Yukino’s head.

“It’s fine. You know he knows that more than anyone. Also, you’ve always been stupid pushy anyway, it’s always been annoying.”

Her head being patted, Yukino swiftly turned her head away. Then, as if embarrassed, she complained softly.

「姉さんに言われたくない……、姉さんもめんどくさいもの……」

まったくだ。自分でからかっておいて、そのくせわざわざ慰めるなんて愛情表現が歪みすぎている。本当に、誰に似たのだか。苦笑交じりに愛娘たちを見守っていると、陽乃はじとっとした目で雪乃を睨み、その頬をつつく。

「あの子よりマシですー。外堀埋められた隙に内堀掘り始めるような子だし。誘ってもたぶんあの手この手を使って逃げ回るんじゃない？」

「……まぁ、たぶん、そうね」

“I don’t want to hear it from you... You’re also annoying...”

That’s exactly right. Going out and teasing her, and then going out of her way to comfort her as if she wasn’t just teasing her is quite a twisted way to show love. Really, just like someone else I know. As I was watching my beloved daughters with a wry smile, Haruno stared Yukino down, poking her cheek.

"Easier than him. Dealing with him is like being doomed to push that boulder up that mountain for eternity. Even if you invited him over, wouldn't he use every excuse in the book not to come?"

"Well, I mean, you might be right."

雪乃が安堵とも呆れともつかないため息を吐く。

すると、妻がぱちりと扇子を鳴らし、満足げに頷いた。

「だったら、その手を全部潰すしかないわね」

にこやかに、どころかいっそ愉快げな妻の声音は明るく弾んでいるのに、私の背にはぞくりとした寒気が走った。

妻の言い草が物騒だったから、だけではない。不穏なことを言う割りに瞳がやけにキラキラしているから、だけでもない。

その感覚に覚えがあったから、私は寒気がしたのだろう。それこそ二十年以上前に味わった追い詰められる獲物の気分が蘇ったのだ。

Whether out of relief or exasperation, Yukino exhaled.

Right then, with a snap, my wife whipped her fan open, giving a nod of satisfaction.

"If so, then we don't have a choice but to crush those excuses."

As cheerfully -- no, as amusedly as my wife's tone came off, I still felt a chill run up my spine.

It wasn't just because what she said was disturbing, nor was it because her eyes were sparkling even as disturbing as her words were.

I felt the chill because I've sensed this before. It was just as if the helplessness of being cornered prey from over twenty years ago had resurfaced.

こんな極めて個人的な感覚は誰かと共有できる類いのものではない。実際、雪乃は妻の言っていることが未だ腑に落ちていないのか、はてと小首を傾げている。

だが、陽乃はピンと来たらしい。すぐさま、にやりと妻によく似た笑みを浮かべる。

「……そっか。じゃ、まずは雪乃ちゃんの逃げ道から潰さないと」

「は？　え、ちょっと姉さん、何をするつもりなの？　何かわからないけど絶対ろくなことにならないからやめて」

A sensation as personal as this one is not one that anyone can sympathize with. Perhaps what my wife had said had not yet fully come together for Yukino, who had tilted her head to the side a bit in puzzlement.

But it had definitely come together for Haruno. Immediately, a smile similar to my wife creeped up her lips.

"I see. Then first off, we've gotta snuff out Yukino’s escape routes."

"Huh? Wait, hold on a sec. Just what are you thinking? I don't know what you're talking about but it's definitely nothing good so please shut up."

だしぬけに言われ、雪乃は首を捻る。そして不安に顔を曇らせて陽乃の手を掴んだ。だが、陽乃は雪乃をまぁまぁと押しとどめると、にこぱーっとした笑みで私に振り返った。

「ね、お父さん。雪乃ちゃん、お父さんに会ってもらいたい人がいるんだって」

「……へ？」

雪乃がぽかーんと口を開けて固まる。次第に陽乃の言ったことが理解できたのか、じんわりと頬が朱色に染まり始めた。

Taken aback by Haruno, Yukino fully tilted her head to the side. Then, an uneasy shadow cast upon her face, she grabbed Haruno's arm. However, pushing Yukino back while telling her to relax, Haruno turned to me with a brilliant smile.

"Hey Dad. Yukino was telling me she has someone she wants you to meet."

"...Pardon?"

Yukino froze, her mouth gaping open. Slowly understanding what Haruno meant, a blush slowly flooded her cheeks.

これまでは私も蚊帳の外にいたからこそ、それらしき話題に触れても聞き流すことができていた。しかし、面と向かって話を振られてしまえば、さすがに聞かなかった振りはできない。私は居住まいを正すと、じっと雪乃の瞳を見つめる。

「雪乃。……そうなのかい？」

「え、そ、いえ、そんなことは……」

Because I've been kept in the dark until now, I've been able to allow conversations with topics like this one to fly over my head. But of course, when I'm face to face with a conversation like this, I can't pretend not to hear it. I straightened myself up in my seat, and I looked Yukino in the eye.

"Yukino. Is that true?"

"Uh-- that's-- no-- It's not like..."

ぶんぶん手を振ったかと思えば、その手でしきりに前髪を直したり、顔を扇いだり、手櫛で髪を梳いたりと雪乃の動きは忙しない。

「雪乃」

だが、妻が静かな声音で呼ばわると、ぱたりと手を下ろした。赤くなった頬を隠すように俯いていたが、やがて観念したように大きく深呼吸し、雪乃は小さな声で囁くように切り出した。

At first it seemed as if she was only waving her hand in denial. But then she began restlessly running through her bangs, fanning her face, and combing through her hair with her fingers.

"Yukino."

But then, being called by my wife in her quiet voice, her hands dropped in an instant. Yukino looked down in an attempt to hide her blushing cheeks, but she eventually heaved a deep sigh of resignation, and in a small, hushed voice, began talking.

「えっと……。その、私も、彼もそういうのはあまり得意ではない、というか。苦手だし好きではないから、たぶん、とても時間がかかるし……、今すぐではないけれど……」

照れくさそうに、私から顔を背けながらも、時にこちらの様子をちらと窺ってはまたすぐに目を逸らして、雪乃はとつとつと言葉を紡ぐ。

私はそれを黙って聞くほかない。こんなに真剣に、そして慎重に、けしてまちがうまいと考え考えしながらも真摯に語り掛ける娘の声を遮ることなどできるはずがない。

“Umm... Right... Neither me, nor him are good at this kind of thing, type of thing. We’re kind of bad at it, we don’t like it either, and so this might take a lot of time... I might not be able to talk about it right away, but...”

Flusteredly turning away from me, but also taking brief glimpses at me before quickly turning her eyes elsewhere, Yukino stammered, stringing words together.

There was nothing else for me to do besides keep quiet and listen. There is absolutely no way I could dare interrupt the earnest, careful, and sincere voice of my daughter, who was determined to get this right.

「父さんに、いつか、紹介……します」

なにより、そんな嬉しそうに、はにかんだ微笑みで言われてしまったら、否やを唱えることなどできやしない。

「ん……。ああ、そうか……」

つんと鼻の奥が痛んだ。吐き出す息は湿りけを帯びてやけに重い。

“Some day, I’ll introduce him... to you.”

Above all else, knowing I’m being talked to through a smile this bashful, in a manner this joyful, how could I possibly object to anything?

“Uh-- Oh, I see...”

An astringent sting welled up my nose. My cobbled breath left a wall of moisture, awfully heavy.

娘が生まれた時に、いつかやってくるであろうと思っていた瞬間は、想像していたよりもはるかに早く、そしてあっけなく訪れてしまった。

何事か口にしなければ、私はこのままため息を吐き続けることになってしまうだろう。それはあまりに情けないので、とりあえず頷きながら言葉に似た何かを口にする。

「そうだな、うん、わかった……。しかしまぁしばらくは私もばたばたしているから、落ち着いたら、な……。そしたら、まぁ、そのうち……」

When my daughter was born, I had a thought that this moment would happen sometime down the road. But it happened far faster and far more abruptly than I had imagined.

If I don’t say something now, I might be here, exhaling breath after breath, forever. That would be awfully pathetic, so while nodding, I at least went and spoke something vaguely resembling words.

“Right, okay, I got it... But I’m going to be busy for a bit, so after things clear up, or something... After that, well, in the meantime...”

そう。そのうち、徐々に私も慣れていけるだろう。娘が我が手を離れていくことに。

だから、あともうほんの少しだけ、この時間を続けさせてもらいたい……。

思った矢先、妻がぱちりと扇子を閉じて、なにか勝手なことを言い出していた。

「そうね。六月半ばなら空いているからそこにしましょう」

「なぜ母さんが決めるんだ……」

Right. In the meantime, I’ll slowly get used to things. Used to my daughter slipping away from me.

So please, if even just for a little bit longer, if things could continue like this...
Right as these thoughts hit me, my wife snapped her hand fan shut, and said something out of line.
“I see. I’m free in mid-June, so let’s talk then.”
“Why is it her who gets to decide...”

私が震える声音で問うと、うっすらと涙で滲んだ視界の中、妻はにっこりと微笑んだ。

「こうでもしないと、あなた、逃げるから。先手を打っておかないとね」

まるで恋する乙女のような、お出かけ前の少女のような、輝きの宿るまっすぐな瞳は、出会ったころと変わらずに、今も美しく、愛らしい。

純粋無垢とは程遠く、可愛らしい打算が滲んだ小悪魔めいた蠱惑的な笑顔には、二十数年経っても、敵う気がしない。

I asked in a shaky voice, and as my vision was becoming lightly stained by tears, my wife broke out into a smile.
“If we don’t do it like this, you, you’re just going to run away. I’ve got to strike first here.”
Like a young lover girl, like a girl just about to head out, with eyes which house brilliance and shoot forward, not changed at all since we met, still beautiful now, adorably.
A cute, fascinating smile, far from purity or innocence, blotted with calculation, like that of a little devil. I’m no match for that, even after twenty years.

私が愕然としていると、視界の端では陽乃が雪乃に耳打ちしている。

「雪乃ちゃん、ああやるんだよ」

「勉強になるわ……」

しきりにこくこくと頷く雪乃の顔を見て、私は密かに、まだ見ぬ彼に同情した。

いずれ、その彼も、私のように追い込まれて追い詰められて、手も足も出ない状態になるのだろう。なんなら口を出すことさえできないのだ。

I stood aghast, and in the corner of my vision was Haruno whispering into Yukino’s ear.

“Yukino, like that. That’s how it’s done.”

“Wow, that should come in handy...”

Seeing Yukino nodding rapidly, I secretly began to feel for this boy I haven’t seen.

Someday, just like me, this boy will be driven from corner into corner, with no means of escape, won’t he. Worse, he won’t even be able to get a word out.

今も、雪ノ下家の三女神は、私をよそに来るべく邂逅へ思いを馳せ、気まぐれな会話を繰り広げていた。

「でも、普通に誘っても来ないでしょ、あの子」

「なにかきっかけがあればいいのだけれど……」

陽乃が手酌でロックグラスに酒を注ぎながら言えば、雪乃は柔らかな唇に手を当て、しばし考えこむ。眉間に寄ったしわから察するに、ずいぶんな難題らしかったが、妻はふわりと扇子を広げると即座に答えを示して見せた。

Even now, indifferent to me, the three goddesses of the Yukinoshita household had shifted their thinking to their chance meeting with this boy, carrying out their fickle conversation.

“But normally there’s no way he’d come even if we invited him, that boy.”

“It’d be good if we could find a good reason, though...”

Saying this, Haruno poured herself another drink into her rock glass, and Yukino put a hand to her soft lips, taking a moment to think. Judging from her furrowed brow, this seemed like a tough problem to crack, but my wife softly spread her hand fan, and immediately put up a solution.

「きっかけね……。なるほど。プロムのようなイベントごとなら、私もお父さんも自然にかかわる可能性があるわね」

「ええ。仕事だからって言い訳があれば、大抵のことは受け入れてしまうから、あの人」

　雪乃が呆れたように、そしてどこか誇らしげに、件の彼について語れば、妻は頬に手をやり、嬉しそうに笑う。

「あら、それはいいことを聞いたわ。労働力としては理想的ね」

“A reason... I see. If it’s an event like prom, then your father and I might naturally get involved.”

“Yes. If you call it work, he’ll take on mostly anything, that boy.”

Yukino talked about the boy in question exasperatedly, but also somewhat triumphantly, and my wife put a hand to her cheek, giggling delightedly.

“Oh? That’s good to hear. Perfectly ideal for hard labor.”

「ていうか、時期考え直した方がいいんじゃない？　普通に受験でそれどころじゃないでしょ。なんだったら受験を言い訳にして、『お互いのために距離を置いたほうがいい』とか気持ち悪いこと言い出すタイプよ、アレ」

　陽乃はけらけら笑いながら言うが、雪乃は一切笑っていない。

「本当に言い出しそうだから困るわ……」

「なんなら雪乃ちゃんが言い出しそうだよね」

“By the way, wouldn’t it be good to rethink the date? It’s exam season, of course, so this wouldn’t be the time for that. Well really, he seems like the type to use exams as an excuse and say something gross like ‘It’s best for both of us to put some space between us’, that guy.”

Haruno said this with a cackle, but Yukino wasn’t laughing at all.

“The fact that I could actually see him saying that...”

“You might very well say that too, Yukino.”

ぷふーっと遠慮なく爆笑する陽乃と、あからさまにむっとする雪乃。二人を見つめて、妻はふっと柔らかな笑みを浮かべている。

「それもそうね……。彼、成績はどうなの？　どのあたりを受験するとか聞いているの？」

「え、ええ……。たぶん私と同じようなところを受けると思うけれど……」

There was Haruno, laughing heartily without reserve, and then there was Yukino, visibly annoyed. Staring at the two, my wife broke out into a gentle smile.

“That’s right... That boy, how are his grades? Have you heard which colleges he’s applying to?”

“Y-- Yes... I think he’s probably applying to the same places as me, but...”

妻に問い詰められ、雪乃がへどもど答えると、それを肴に陽乃がロックグラスを傾けつつ、楽しげにうそぶく。

「違う大学……、新しい出会い……、そして偶然の再会……。前途多難だねぇ」

「姉さん黙って」

Pressed with questions from my wife, Yukino stammered out a reply. Tipsily relishing in it all, Haruno tilted her rock glass, and started yapping amusedly.

“Different universities, new encounters... And then after, maybe a coincidental reunion... Yeah, your prospects seem pretty grim.”

“Haruno, shut up.”

またぞろ二人の言い争いが始まるのをしり目に、私はそっとリビングを後にする。

これ以上、ガールズトークを聞いているのは私の心臓に悪そうだ。無論、言うまでもなく妻もガールと言っていいくらいに若い。

去り際に壁掛け時計に目をやれば、まだ夜更けと呼ぶには浅い時間だ。今ならまだ店も開いているだろう。

久しぶりにゆっくり一人で飲みたい気分だった。

Watching the two begin to quarrel yet again in the corner of my eye, I quietly retreated from the living room.

Hearing any more girls' talk would be bad for my heart. Of course, it need not be mentioned that my wife is young enough to be one of the girls.

Glancing up at the clock as I left, I saw that it was still too early to call the night late. Bars should still be open.

For the first time in a long time, I felt like leisurely drinking by myself.

寝室から降りてきた時とは違い、いくぶんか軽やかになった足取りで、私は二階へと上がっていく。手早く着替えて、行きつけのバーに向かうとしよう。

妻にかけてもらったコートをクローゼットから引っ張り出すと、さっと羽織って、私は抜き足差し足忍び足で玄関を出た。戻って来るときはきっと千鳥足だ。

そっと音を立てずに扉を閉めて、玉砂利を踏まぬよう慎重に石畳を歩く。

Unlike when I descended the stairs from the bedroom, I headed up the stairs with a bit of a spring in my step. I quickly changed, and set out for my favorite bar.

I took the coat that my wife put away out of the closet, I threw it on, and I tiptoed out the front door. When I come back, I will definitely be staggering drunk.

Without making a sound, I closed the door, and, being sure not to step on gravel, I carefully walked on the cobblestone path.

門を出ると、月影さやかに桜吹雪が舞い散った。

男子家を出ずれば七人の敵あり。

愛しい娘を父親から奪い去らんとする我が怨敵。

ともに女神たちに立ち向かわんとする我が強敵。

――どうやら今日、また一人、私の敵が増えたらしい。

了

As I went out the gate, a flurry of cherry blossoms scattered amongst the moonlight.

When a man steps out of his house, he has seven enemies.

Whoever rips a father’s dear daughter away from him is his sworn enemy.

At the same time, whoever dares to stand up to the goddesses is a formidable enemy.

It seems that today, once more, I’ve gained yet another enemy.

Fin